

Conflict-Related Sexual Violence (CRSV) & Reparation Deficits in Nigeria: A Policy Assessment (1995–2023)

Delivering Direct Victim Compensation and Support Without Court Delays Through Administrative Reparations

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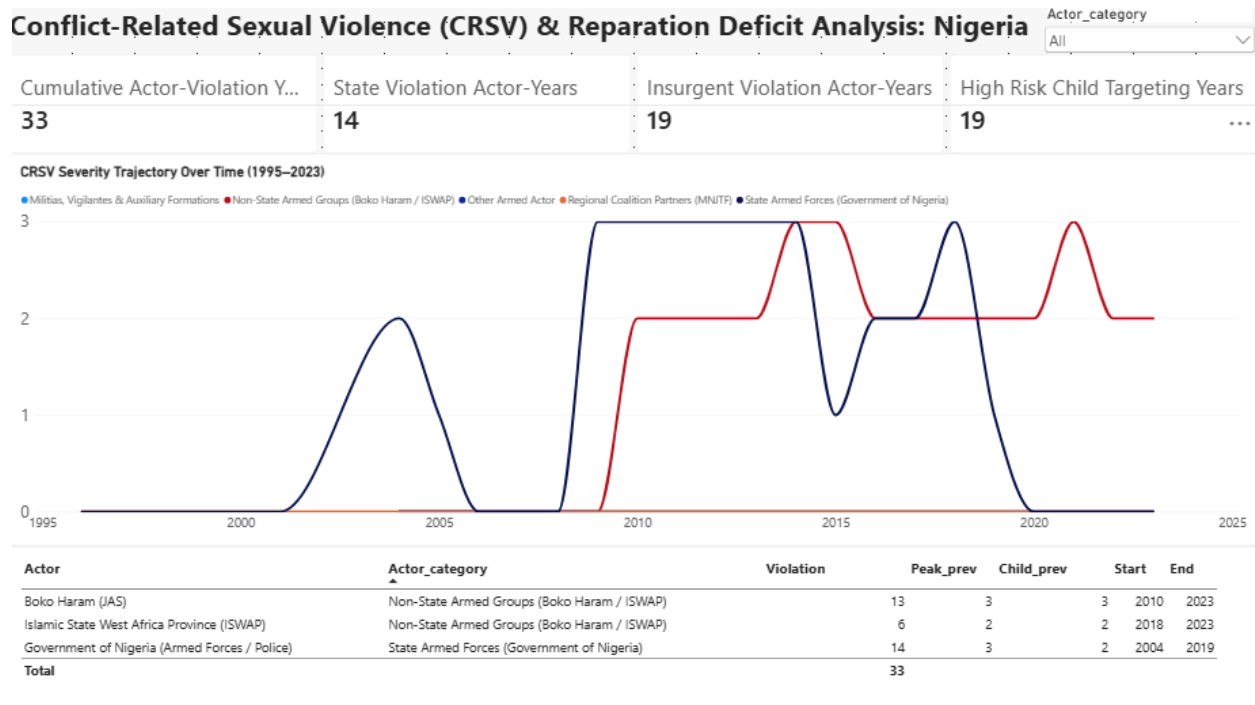
1. Executive Summary

This report looks closely at Conflict-Related Sexual Violence (CRSV) in Nigeria over a 28-year period, from 1995 to 2023. Using standardized, long-term conflict data, it tracks how often these abuses happened, who committed them, and why survivors have struggled to get meaningful support.

Core Findings

- **Combined Years of Documented Abuse (33 Actor-Years):** Between 1995 and 2023, armed groups and security forces in Nigeria recorded a combined total of 33 actor-years of sexual violence. Because government forces and insurgent groups operated at the exact same time during intense periods of fighting, this number counts each group's recorded actions separately, rather than 33 individual calendar years on a clock.
- **Documented State Force Involvements (14 Actor-Years / 42.4%):** Government security forces (including military formations and police commands) account for 14 recorded actor-years of violations between 2004 and 2019. Because the government has an official legal duty to protect citizens and uphold human rights, this record makes it clear that the state must take the lead in providing administrative reparations and ensuring such harm never happens again.
- **Continuous Insurgent Violence (19 Actor-Years / 57.6%):** Non-state armed groups specifically Boko Haram (JAS) and ISWAP carried out sustained, widespread violence. They maintained the highest level of severity (Level 3) continuously through 2023.
- **High Number of Attacks Involving Children (19 Actor-Years):** In 19 actor-years, documented violence against children reached massive or widespread levels. This shows that children have carried an enormous burden during the conflict, creating urgent needs for education, healthcare, and long-term support for families.
- **The Gap in Support for Survivors:** Even though the data shows decades of widespread harm, survivors still cannot get victim compensation through the courts. Right now, compensation is tied to whether an attacker is caught, charged, and found guilty in a criminal trial. But most perpetrators are dead, missing, or hidden in the bush. On top of that, terrorism court cases focus only on national security, not on helping victims. Because of this, thousands of survivors receive zero medical care, surgery for internal injuries, or trauma counseling. There is an urgent need for the government to step in and set up direct administrative reparations.

Fig 1. Conflict-Related Sexual Violence(CRSV) & Reparation Deficit Dashboard



2. How the Data Was Analyzed

2.1 Scope and Units of Measurement

- **Time Period:** 1995 to 2023 across Nigeria.
- **Groups Analyzed:** 1) Government Security Forces (Nigerian military formations, joint task forces, and national police units); 2) Insurgent Groups (Boko Haram / JAS and ISWAP).
- **Unit of Count (The Actor-Year):** We count by 'Actor-Year'. If two different groups committed abuses during the same calendar year, each group gets counted separately for that year.
- **Severity Scale (0 to 3):** Benchmark scale based on global SVAC standards:
 - Level 0: None reported
 - Level 1: Isolated incidents (fewer than 25 victims)
 - Level 2: Massive or widespread (25 to hundreds of victims)
 - Level 3: Systematic or strategic (widespread use, mass kidnappings, or abuses in detention camps)

2.2 Summary of Key Calculations

- **Total Recorded Actor-Years with Violations:** 33 Actor-Years
- **Share Committed by State Security Forces:** 14 out of 33 Years = 42.4%
- **Share Committed by Insurgent Groups (JAS/ISWAP):** 19 out of 33 Years = 57.6%
- **Years Involving High-Level Harm to Children:** 19 Actor-Years

3. Summary of Findings by Group

Group Name	Category	Documented Violation Years	Highest Overall Severity (0–3)	Highest Child Severity (0–3)	Years Active in Data
Boko Haram (JAS)	Insurgent Group	13	Level 3 (Systematic)	Level 3 (Systematic)	2010–2023
Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP)	Insurgent Group	6	Level 2 (Massive)	Level 2 (Massive)	2018–2023
Government Forces (Military & Police)	State Security Forces	14	Level 3 (Systematic)	Level 2 (Massive)	2004–2019
Total Combined Profile	All Groups Combined	33	Level 3	Level 3	1995–2023

Understanding the Trends Over Time

State Force Violations (2004–2019): Records show incidents during early internal security operations and during peak counter-insurgency operations around 2014 to 2016. These occurred in regular field operations, screening sites, and camps for displaced persons. Because the government has a duty to protect all citizens under the constitution and international law, these 14 documented years show why the state must fund and provide reparations directly, without making survivors wait for court cases against individual officers.

Insurgent Violence (Post-2015): When Boko Haram split into JAS and ISWAP around 2016, violence spread across different areas. JAS focused heavily on abductions and forced marriages involving young girls, while ISWAP controlled rural communities. Because fighters and commanders in the bush cannot be brought to regular civil courts for compensation, survivors have no way to get damages from them. Therefore, the government has a duty to step in and provide support to these victims directly.

4. What the Data Cannot Tell Us & Practical Recommendations

4.1 Listening Directly to Survivors

Conflict datasets are useful because they give us numbers, dates, and evidence of what armed groups did. But numbers alone do not show how survivors are coping, what their daily medical needs are, or what kind of help they actually want. To design programs that truly help people, these numbers must be paired with direct input from the survivors themselves.

4.2 Practical Recommendations

- **1. Set Up a Survivor-Led Registration System:** Work with trusted local women's groups and civil society organizations to create a safe, confidential sign-up process. This system should record the specific support each family needs, including:
 - Financial and Material Support: Direct cash grants, business startup support, and help recovering lost farm lands or livestock.
 - Medical and Psychological Care: Free treatment, reconstructive surgery, specialized care for fistula injuries, and trauma therapy.
 - Help for Children Born of War: Fast-track birth registration and legal papers, along with school fee assistance and learning supplies.

- Dignity and Healing: Public recognition of what survivors endured and memorials that honor their survival.
- **2. Set Up an Administrative Reparations Board:** Separate victim compensation from court trials. Given the documented history of harm over the years, the Federal Government and state governments in the Northeast should establish an administrative reparations fund. This board will provide immediate financial and medical support to survivors right away, without requiring criminal trials or waiting for peace agreements.
- **3. Include Victim Support in Peace and Reintegration Programs:** Whenever programs are set up to handle surrendered fighters or bring peace to communities, include direct consultation and compensation for victims. Making sure survivors receive care alongside wider peace efforts builds real community healing and trust.

Appendix A: Data Provenance, Acquisition Pipeline & Licensing

A.1 Primary Data Source

The quantitative metrics used in this assessment originate from the Sexual Violence in Armed Conflict (SVAC) database, maintained collaboratively by the Peace Research Institute Oslo (PRIO), the University of Gothenburg, and the Harvard Kennedy School.

- **Core Dataset:** SVAC Actor-Year Dataset (Version 3.3).
- **Citation Standard:** Cohen, Dara Kay, and Ragnhild Nordås. Sexual Violence in Armed Conflict (SVAC) Dataset. Peace Research Institute Oslo (PRIO) & Harvard Kennedy School.
- **Primary Documentation Streams:** The dataset triangulates findings from three authoritative monitoring sources: 1) United Nations Secretary-General Annual Reports on CRSV and CAAC; 2) United States Department of State Country Reports on Human Rights Practices; 3) Authoritative human rights reporting from Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch.

A.2 Acquisition & Transformation Pipeline

- **1. Extraction:** The full global SVAC repository was accessed through PRIO's open data repository and filtered to extract conflict actors operating within Nigeria from 1995 to 2023.
- **2. Standardization:** Entities were standardized into state statutory forces and non-state insurgent factions (JAS and ISWAP).
- **3. Metric Calculation:** Prevalence scores across all three source streams were evaluated using max-aggregation logic to construct standardized integer variables (max_prevalence and child_prevalence, scaled 0-3). DAX measures were built in Microsoft Power BI Desktop by Sayemo Harris to compute institutional exposure totals and longitudinal trajectories.

A.3 Open Data Licensing & Attribution Terms

- **Data Terms of Use & Licensing:** The underlying SVAC dataset is provided by PRIO / Harvard Kennedy School for open research and policy analysis under standard academic attribution terms.
- **Analytical Output License:** This derived compilation, analytical model, and report are released under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0) License.

- **Permitted Use:** Open to sharing, copying, adapting, and redistributing in any medium or format for research, reporting, advocacy, and policy development.
- **Attribution Requirement:** Any secondary publication, policy brief, dashboard, or report using these metrics must acknowledge the original data collectors (Cohen & Nordås / PRIO), with citation of this analytical compilation and model adaptation attributed to: Harris, Sayemo. Conflict-Related Sexual Violence (CRSV) & Reparation Deficits in Nigeria: An Empirical Policy Assessment (1995-2023). Analytical Dashboard & Policy Brief, 2026.